‘normal’ bat, it is supposed to give you 20 per cent more hitting power. And the new bat still falls within the ICC’s regulations, so it’s legal. In the hands of a smasher like Hayden – not a guy who really needs any extra help when it comes to launching balls over the ropes – the Mongoose was devastating.

I haven’t tried the Mongoose yet, but my Deccan Chargers teammate Dwayne Smith had a couple in his possession and I picked one up in the changing room during one of our games. But it just felt too weird to me. I wanted to assume the stance of a baseball player, not a cricketer. I think with the smaller blade, you’re at a disadvantage against quick, short-pitched bowling. But the bat clearly works for Hayden. Besides the fact that the ball doesn’t get up much on the Indian wickets, any bowler with half a brain knows that, no matter what wicket you’re playing on, pitching anything short to Hayden is a *bad* idea. You *are* going to get pumped. It’s as certain as death and taxes.

I have absolutely loved playing in the IPL. With Adam Gilchrist as captain, Darren Lehmann as coach and South African legend Goolam Rajah as team manager, the Chargers are among the most professional outfits I have ever played for, especially in team preparation.

But, there’s a relaxed side to it too. The sponsors arrange a lot of social functions to which at least 40 models are invited at a time. Seriously. At least 40 models at every party. Everything has to be ultra-glamorous. This sort of thing doesn’t happen anywhere else in the cricket world, believe me. I think it’s particularly great for the older guys, like me, who have played international cricket for such a long time. While we are still able to be professional in a tournament, we also make the most of the ample opportunities to relax and enjoy ourselves, which is probably the part I enjoy the most.

Even though we’re the defending champions, the Chargers aren’t one of the glam teams in the IPL. Our owners aren’t Bollywood stars like the Royals’ Shilpa Shetty or the Knight Riders’ Shahrukh Khan. The Chargers feels more like a family. They’re just a great bunch of lads, from legends like Gilchrist and characters like Andrew Symonds, to the younger Indian players like Rohit Sharma and RP Singh.

And the buzz at the ground is just incredible to witness in person. You get some idea of the noise the Indian cricket fans generate if you watch it on TV, but actually experiencing it in person is something else. It’s so bladdy loud that even if you yell at a teammate 25 metres away, he won’t hear you.